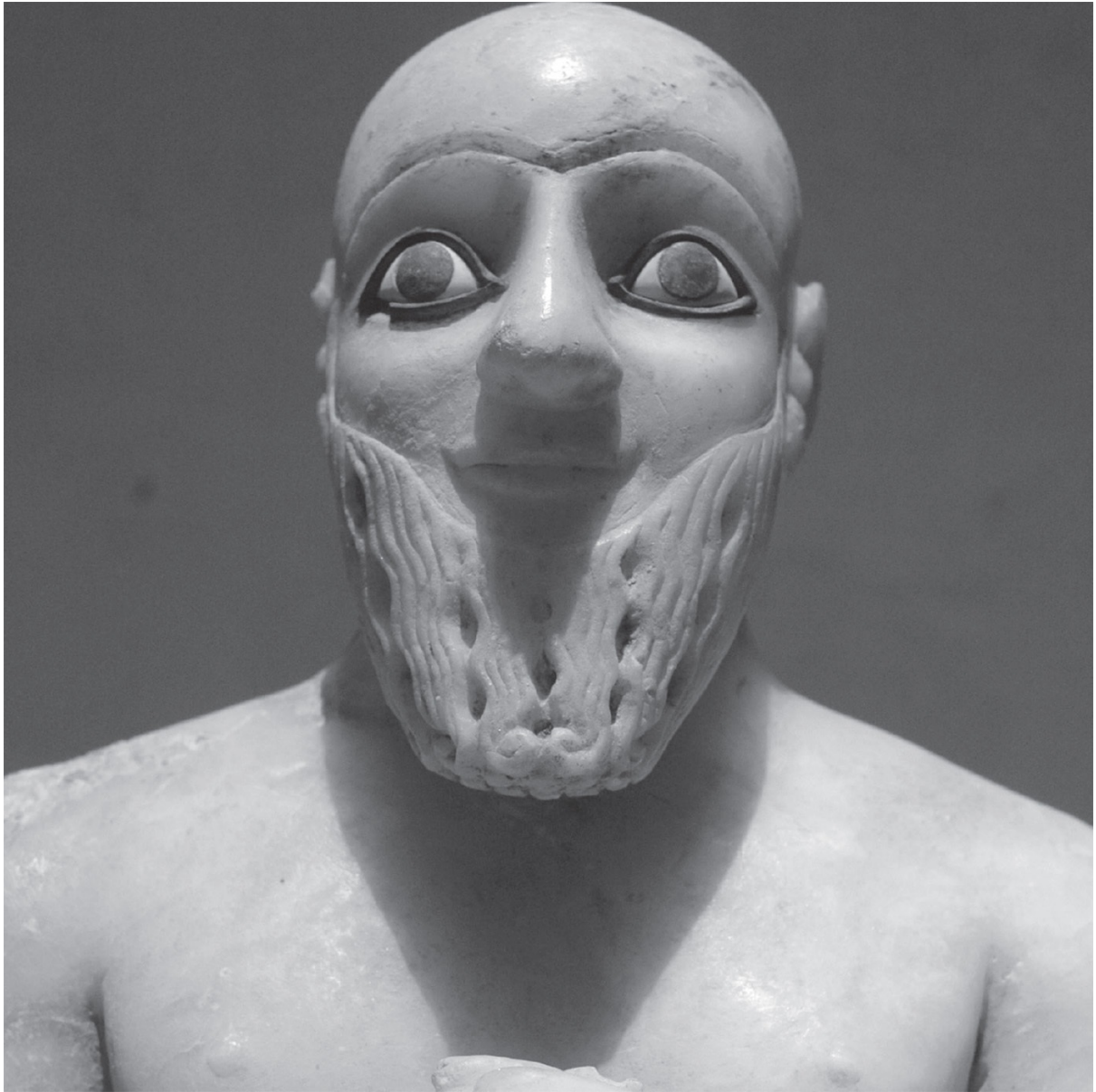


Sumerian and Akkadian art

Often called the 'Cradle of Civilization', Mesopotamia comprised an area roughly corresponding to present-day Israel, Iraq, part of Iran, Jordan, Lebanon, Turkey and Syria, and flourished c.4,000–500 BCE.

Neolithic cultures flourished here and it was the site of numerous inventions, including the first writing system, the wheel, the arch and the plough, and also saw the earliest implementations of law, medicine and science. Sophisticated irrigation systems also generated abundant harvests, leading to healthier populations.

The first Mesopotamian civilizations were the Sumerians and Akkadians. From c.4000 BCE, the Sumerians produced art that expressed their relationships with their gods and the natural world. In c.2300 BCE, they were conquered by the Akkadians. With slight differences, both civilizations produced ceramics, stone and clay statues, reliefs, steles and mosaics. Lifelike animal forms and human figures predominated. Fairly detailed, they are also rigid-looking, while figures and animals have large, expressive eyes.



Bust of Ebiḥ-II, c.2400 BCE